skepticism, with South African opinion leaders in academia, business, and the press (although not within the ANC) suggesting that their country's participation in the BRICS ought to be evaluated in terms of its contribution to helping South Africa and its neighbors escape natural resource dependence and move up the production value chain,[272] or even that South Africa would be better served by focusing on improving its export performance than engaging further with the BRICS.[273] Some researchers at the prestigious South African Institute of International Affairs (SAIIA) concluded, "The BRICS alliance seems to have yielded limited tangible economic benefits for South Africa," suggesting instead alternative groupings such as a hypothetical "small group of emerging economies and middle powers with close similarities to South Africa . . . , including Canada, Nigeria, Turkey, Mexico, and Australia."[274] Other scholars promoted building on the existing FOCAC or IAFS processes.[275] While the BRICS do have enthusiastic promoters among the commentariat,[276] and the Zuma government and the ANC express pro forma support for it, overall the BRICS have not claimed a high place on the national foreign policy agenda. Somewhat surprisingly, then, given what appears from the outside to have been South Africa's extraordinary good fortune in having been admitted to the exclusive BRICS club while other aspirants such as Mexico, Indonesia, and Turkey were denied, there has been a limited commitment from the national political authorities, along with considerable ambivalence from academia and the private sector about the usefulness of the BRICS for South Africa.

Anticapitalist Rhetoric—Yet Milder Grievances with Global Financial Governance

The Zuma government's somewhat tepid response to its invitation to join the BRICS club partially results from South African policymakers being relatively more satisfied with global financial governance than leaders of the original four member-states. Despite South Africa's rhetorical anti-imperialism—in speeches of senior politicians, including President Zuma, often equated with resisting capitalism per se—the country's relations with the Bretton Woods institutions have been relatively peaceful. Although South Africa followed India's lead in blocking any conclusion to the Doha Round in the WTO that would liberalize agricultural trade without